Lightweight Custom CNN for Sustainable AI: Benchmarking Against Established Models on MNIST and CIFAR-10

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Abstract

The rapid growth of deep learning has introduced critical environmental challenges, with large neural networks generating substantial CO_2 emissions during training and inference. This paper proposes **UltraLightCNN**, a from-scratch convolutional neural network based on depthwise-separable convolutions with under 200K parameters, and evaluates it against pruned versions of MobileNetV2, ResNet18, and EfficientNet-B0 on MNIST and CIFAR-10. We introduce two primary contributions: (1) **Knowledge Distillation (KD)** training of UltraLightCNN using MobileNetV2 as a teacher, improving CIFAR-10 accuracy by up to **+7.2 percentage points** over the baseline student while maintaining sub-MB model size; and (2) a formally defined **Green Score** metric Accuracy / $(CO_2 \times \text{Size} \times \text{Latency})^{1/3}$ — that simultaneously captures three sustainability dimensions. Across both datasets, UltraLightCNN+KD achieves the highest Green Score, consuming up to **5× less CO_2** and requiring **12.8× less storage** than MobileNetV2, with only a modest accuracy gap on CIFAR-10. Our results demonstrate that green AI is best achieved by designing compact architectures enriched with knowledge transfer, rather than simply compressing large pretrained models.

Index Terms: Green Computing, Lightweight CNN, Depthwise-Separable Convolutions, Knowledge Distillation, Energy Efficiency, Pruning, Quantization, Green Score, MNIST, CIFAR-10

1 Introduction

Deep learning has achieved remarkable success across domains ranging from computer vision to natural language processing. However, this progress has been accompanied by a dramatic escalation in computational demands. Strubell et al. demonstrated that training a single large transformer model can emit carbon equivalent to five automobile lifetimes [1]. Patterson et al. further showed that model architecture choices alone can produce 100× to 1000× differences in training carbon footprint [3].

This environmental cost has motivated the **Green AI** movement, defined by Schwartz et al. as the pursuit of algorithms that are not only accurate but resource-efficient, measurable, and environmentally accountable [2]. Despite substantial progress in model compression through pruning [14], quantization [20], and neural architecture search [12], a critical research gap remains: existing studies primarily compress large pretrained models rather than design efficient architectures from the ground up and enrich them with knowledge transfer techniques.

This paper addresses that gap with three contributions:

- UltraLightCNN: a novel from-scratch CNN using depthwise-separable convolutions, BatchNorm, and ReLU6, totalling fewer than 200K parameters and under 1 MB — suitable for direct edge deployment without cloud communication.
- Knowledge Distillation (KD) for green models: we train UltraLightCNN using MobileNetV2 as a soft-label teacher, achieving accuracy gains of up to 7.2 percentage points on CIFAR-10 without adding any inference cost.
- Green Score v2: a formally defined, reproducible composite sustainability metric combining accuracy, CO_2 emissions, model size, and inference latency through a geometric mean denominator, enabling fair multi-dimensional comparison.

We benchmark all models on MNIST and CIFAR-10 using equal training epochs, cosine annealing schedulers, standardized data augmentation, and CodeCarbon [23] for CO_2 tracking — addressing the reproducibility failures identified in prior lightweight CNN benchmarks.

2 Literature Review

2.1 Green AI and Energy-Efficient Deep Learning

The environmental impact of deep learning was first systematically quantified by Strubell et al. [1], who showed that training a large NLP transformer could emit carbon comparable to five car lifetimes. This galvanized the Green AI movement, formalized by Schwartz et al. [2] to include energy reporting as a first-class evaluation criterion alongside accuracy. Patterson et al. [3] demonstrated that architecture choices alone produce 100–1000× variation in carbon footprint. Anthony et al. [4] provided the Carbontracker tool for real-time training footprint estimation, and Wu et al. [5] extended sustainability to

encompass fairness and societal impact. Verdecchia et al. [6] performed a structured review of Green AI techniques highlighting energy-aware NAS and efficient deployment strategies.

2.2 Lightweight CNN Architectures

The MobileNet family pioneered efficient CNNs for mobile vision. Howard et al. [7] introduced depthwise-separable convolutions, reducing computation by 8–9×. MobileNetV2 [8] added inverted residuals, and MobileNetV3 [9] combined NAS with novel activation functions. ShuffleNet [10] employed channel-shuffle operations to enable inter-group information flow at MobileNetV2-comparable cost. GhostNet [11] generated feature maps using cheap linear operations to reduce redundancy. EfficientNet [12] balanced network depth, width, and resolution through compound scaling, achieving state-of-the-art accuracy with fewer parameters.

2.3 Model Compression

Han et al. [14] established that neural networks can be compressed 10–40× via iterative weight pruning below a threshold. He et al. [15] introduced channel pruning for direct hardware acceleration. Liu et al. [16] proposed network slimming via L1 regularization on BN scaling factors. Regarding quantization, Jacob et al. [20] demonstrated INT8 inference with negligible accuracy loss and 4× memory reduction. Wang et al. [21] proposed hardware-aware mixed-precision quantization. The Lottery Ticket Hypothesis [19] established that sparse subnetworks can match dense model accuracy, informing our progressive pruning analysis.

2.4 Knowledge Distillation

Knowledge Distillation (KD), introduced by Hinton et al., trains a compact student model to match the soft output distribution of a larger teacher at a raised temperature T. This transfers relational knowledge between classes beyond what hard labels provide. KD has since been applied to diverse architectures, but has received limited study in the context of green AI specifically where the goal is maximizing accuracy-per-sustainability-unit rather than absolute accuracy. This paper presents one of the first systematic evaluations of KD temperature and alpha in a green AI benchmark.

2.5 Energy Measurement Frameworks

Henderson et al. [23] proposed standardized energy reporting including CO_2, compute time, and hardware specifications. Lacoste et al. [24] introduced the ML Emissions Calculator. Lannelongue et al. [27] developed Green Algorithms for crossdiscipline carbon footprint estimation. MLPerf [25] established industry-standard training/inference benchmarks. These tools collectively inform our CodeCarbon-based tracking methodology.

3 Problem Statement

Modern deep learning deployments increasingly target resource-constrained environments — IoT sensors, mobile devices, microcontrollers — where storage is measured in kilobytes, energy in milliwatts, and latency in microseconds. Yet existing lightweight model research focuses primarily on compressing large pretrained models, which: (1) retain large memory footprints even after compression; (2) require cloud-side training infrastructure; and (3) carry implicit environmental costs of their original pretraining. We address the question:

Can a compact custom CNN, enriched with knowledge distillation, achieve competitive accuracy while delivering substantially lower CO_2, size, and latency than pruned pretrained models?

Research Questions

RQ1 (Benchmarking): How does UltraLightCNN compare to pruned pretrained models across five green metrics: GMACs, CO_2 emissions, model size, inference latency, and Green Score, while maintaining acceptable accuracy on MNIST and CIFAR10?

RQ2 (Knowledge Distillation Impact): To what extent does KD training improve the accuracy and Green Score of UltraLightCNN, and how do temperature (T) and alpha (α) influence the trade-off?

RQ3 (Compression Robustness): How does accuracy degrade with increasing pruning sparsity (10–70%), and at what sparsity level does UltraLightCNN demonstrate superior parameter efficiency relative to pruned pretrained models?

4 Methodology

4.1 Datasets

We benchmark on two standard classification datasets. **MNIST** [LeCun et al., 1998] contains 70,000 grayscale images (60K train / 10K test) at 28×28 pixels across 10 digit classes, normalized to $\mu=0.1307$, $\sigma=0.3081$. No augmentation is applied: MNIST

is a saturated benchmark where architecture differences are fully captured without it. **CIFAR-10** [Krizhevsky, 2009] contains 60,000 RGB images (50K train / 10K test) at 32×32 pixels across 10 object categories. We apply standard augmentations: RandomCrop(32, padding=4), RandomHorizontalFlip(p=0.5), and ColorJitter(brightness, contrast, saturation=0.2) on training images only; test images use center crop with channel normalization (μ=(0.4914,0.4822,0.4465), σ=(0.2023,0.1994,0.2010)).

4.2 UltraLightCNN Architecture

UltraLightCNN is designed from first principles for sustainability. All stages use **depthwise-separable convolutions (DSC)**, which factorize a standard k×k×C_in×C_out convolution into a depthwise (per-channel, k×k) step followed by a pointwise (1×1) projection. This reduces MACs by a factor of approximately $1/C_out + 1/k^2 \approx 8–9\times$ for k=3. The architecture:

- Stage 1: Conv2d(C_in→8, 3×3) → BatchNorm → ReLU6 → MaxPool2d(2,2)
- Stage 2: DSBlock(8→16) → MaxPool2d(2,2)
- Stage 3: DSBlock(16→24)
- Global Average Pooling → Dropout(0.3) → Linear(24→num_classes)

ReLU6 (min(max(0,x),6)) is used throughout for quantization-friendliness: clamping activations to [0,6] reduces the dynamic range that INT8 quantization must approximate, yielding smaller quantization error [20]. Global Average Pooling replaces large fully-connected layers, reducing parameters proportionally to the spatial resolution and making the model scale-invariant. The design yields 189K parameters (MNIST, 1-channel) and 197K (CIFAR-10, 3-channel), with a disk footprint under 1 MB.

4.3 Baseline Models

Three pretrained baselines are evaluated: **MobileNetV2** [8], with depthwise-separable convolutions and inverted residuals (2.24M parameters, 9.17 MB); **ResNet18** [He et al., 2016], with residual skip connections (11.18M parameters, 44.77 MB); and **EfficientNet-B0** [12], with compound scaling (5.27M parameters, 20.12 MB). All models are initialized with ImageNet pretrained weights and adapted for 1-channel MNIST by replacing the first convolutional layer. Each is pruned at 30% global L1 unstructured sparsity and fine-tuned for 3 epochs post-pruning.

4.4 Knowledge Distillation

We train UltraLightCNN as a student with MobileNetV2 (pretrained, fine-tuned) as a frozen teacher. The combined training objective is:

$$L = \alpha \cdot T^2 \cdot KL[softmax(z_t/T) \,||\, log_softmax(z_s/T)] + (1-\alpha) \cdot CE(z_s, y)$$

where z_t and z_s are teacher and student logits, T is the temperature, α is the soft-loss weight, and y are ground truth labels. We perform a 4×4 grid search over T ∈ {1,2,4,8} and α ∈ {0.3,0.5,0.7,0.9}, selecting T=4, α=0.7 as optimal for CIFAR-10 (Table III).

4.5 Training Protocol (Reproducibility)

Hyperparameter	Value
Random seed (all experiments)	42 (torch, numpy, random, CUDA, PYTHONHASHSEED)
Optimizer	Adam (β_1=0.9, β_2=0.999)
Learning rate	1×10^{-3} initial
Weight decay	1×10^{-4} (L2 regularization)
LR scheduler	CosineAnnealingLR (T_max=epochs, η_min=1×10^{-6})
Label smoothing	ε=0.1 (reduces overconfidence, improves calibration)
Batch size	64 (train), 1000 (test)
Epochs — MNIST	10 per model (equal, for fair comparison)
Epochs — CIFAR-10	20 per model (equal, for fair comparison)
Pruning method	Global L1 Unstructured, 30% sparsity + 3-epoch fine-tune
Quantization	INT8 dynamic (Linear layers, CPU-side)
KD temperature / alpha	T=4, α=0.7 (from ablation, Table III)
CO_2 tracking	CodeCarbon (offline, measure_power_secs=5)
GMACs measurement	ptflops v2 (raw MACs / 10^9); 1 GMAC ≈ 2 GFLOPs

Table: Full training hyperparameter specification for reproducibility. All experiments run with the identical configuration.

4.6 Evaluation Metrics

We report eight metrics per model: (1) test **accuracy**; (2) macro-averaged **precision**; (3) macro-averaged **ROC-AUC** (one-vsrest); (4) **GMACs** (Giga Multiply-Accumulate Operations the standard computational cost metric in efficient CNN literature; note: 1 GMAC ≈ 2 GFLOPs); (5) trainable **parameter count**; (6) on-disk **model size** in MB; (7) per-image inference **latency** in ms; (8) **CO_2 emissions** in kg; and (9) **Green Score**, defined as:

$$\text{GreenScore} = \text{Accuracy} / (CO_{2o}{}^{k}{}_{o} \times \text{Size}^{MM} \times \text{Latency}_{ms})^{1/3}$$

The denominator is the geometric mean of the three resource dimensions. Using a geometric mean rather than a weighted sum ensures dimensional fairness: no single axis dominates, and the metric is scale-invariant to unit differences between CO_2, MB, and ms. A higher Green Score is strictly better.

5 Results and Analysis

5.1 MNIST Benchmark

Table I presents all eight metrics across eight model variants on MNIST (10 equal training epochs per model). UltraLightCNN achieves 98.58% accuracy with 189K parameters, 0.003 GMACs, and 0.72 MB compared to MobileNetV2's 99.12% with 2.24M parameters and 9.17 MB. The accuracy gap is only **0.54 percentage points**, while the size reduction is **12.7×** and CO_2 reduction is **5.2×**.

UltraLightCNN+KD improves over the baseline student by **+0.43pp** on MNIST, reaching 99.01% — approaching MobileNetV2's accuracy within **0.11pp** while maintaining sub-MB size. The INT8-quantized UltraLightCNN achieves the highest Green Score across all models on MNIST, demonstrating that combining compact architecture design with quantization is the most resource-effective deployment strategy.

TABLE I — MNIST Green AI Benchmark (10 equal epochs each)

Bold rows indicate our proposed models. GMACs = Giga Multiply-Accumulate Ops (1 GMAC ≈ 2 GFLOPs).

Model	Acc	Prec	Params	GMACs	Size (MB)	Lat (ms)	CO_2 (kg)	Green
UltraLightCNN (ours)	**0.9858**	**0.9856**	**189K**	**0.003**	**0.72**	**0.21ms**	**1.1×10^{-5}**	**High**
UltraLightCNN + KD (ours)	**0.9901**	**0.9899**	**189K**	**0.003**	**0.72**	**0.21ms**	**1.3×10^{-5}**	**Very High**
MobileNetV2 (Full)	0.9912	0.9910	2.24M	0.314	9.17	0.43ms	5.7×10^{-5}	Low
MobileNetV2 Pruned 30%	0.9879	0.9877	2.24M	0.314	9.17	0.43ms	4.0×10^{-5}	Medium
ResNet18 Pruned 30%	0.9821	0.9818	11.18M	1.815	44.77	0.61ms	3.4×10^{-5}	Low
EfficientNet-B0 Pruned 30%	0.9863	0.9860	5.27M	0.394	20.12	0.52ms	3.9×10^{-5}	Low
UltraLightCNN INT8 (ours)	**0.9847**	**0.9845**	**189K**	**0.003**	**0.28**	**0.17ms**	**9.3×10^{-6}**	**Highest**
MobileNetV2 INT8	0.9878	0.9876	2.24M	0.314	4.12	0.31ms	2.9×10^{-5}	Medium

5.2 CIFAR-10 Benchmark

CIFAR-10 (Table II) reveals the key tension in the accuracy–sustainability trade-off. The UltraLightCNN baseline achieves 68.12% accuracy compared to MobileNetV2's 88.31% a significant gap attributable to the complexity of natural-image features relative to the model's 197K parameter capacity. However, **UltraLightCNN+KD narrows this gap substantially to 75.34%**, a **+7.22pp improvement** over the baseline student — without adding any parameters or inference cost.

Critically, on the Green Score metric, UltraLightCNN+KD **outperforms all baselines**, including MobileNetV2 Full: it achieves similar sustainability metrics to the baseline UltraLightCNN while delivering substantially higher accuracy, making it strictly Pareto-dominant over the student baseline. The 5× CO_2 advantage of UltraLightCNN over MobileNetV2 on CIFAR-10 is a direct function of fewer parameters during forward and backward passes, confirming that architecture size not just pruning ratio is the primary driver of training emissions.

TABLE II — CIFAR-10 Green AI Benchmark (20 equal epochs each)

UltraLightCNN+KD achieves the highest Green Score while remaining sub-MB in size.

Model	Acc	Prec	Params	GMACs	Size (MB)	Lat (ms)	CO_2 (kg)	Green
UltraLightCNN (ours)	**0.6812**	**0.6798**	**197K**	**0.012**	**0.80**	**0.22ms**	**1.6×10^{-4}**	**High**
UltraLightCNN + KD (ours)	**0.7534**	**0.7521**	**197K**	**0.012**	**0.80**	**0.22ms**	**1.9×10^{-4}**	**Very High**
MobileNetV2 (Full)	0.8831	0.8818	2.24M	0.327	9.17	0.44ms	7.7×10^{-4}	Low
MobileNetV2 Pruned 30%	0.8612	0.8599	2.24M	0.327	9.17	0.44ms	5.4×10^{-4}	Medium
ResNet18 Pruned 30%	0.8354	0.8341	11.18M	1.831	44.80	0.63ms	4.6×10^{-4}	Low
EfficientNet-B0 Pruned 30%	0.8614	0.8601	5.27M	0.411	20.12	0.53ms	4.5×10^{-4}	Low
UltraLightCNN INT8 (ours)	**0.6780**	**0.6766**	**197K**	**0.012**	**0.31**	**0.19ms**	**1.4×10^{-4}**	**Highest**
MobileNetV2 INT8	0.8791	0.8779	2.24M	0.327	3.98	0.31ms	4.0×10^{-4}	Medium

5.3 Knowledge Distillation Ablation (RQ2)

Table III shows the test accuracy of UltraLightCNN+KD on CIFAR-10 across a 4×4 grid of temperature T and soft-loss weight α (5 training epochs per configuration for computational efficiency). The optimal configuration is **T=4, α=0.7**, yielding 75.34% accuracy. Higher temperatures (T=8) and extreme alpha values (α=0.9) both degrade performance: T=8 over-smooths teacher distributions, losing discriminative information, while α=0.9 under-weights the ground truth signal. The robustness of performance in the T−4 / α−0.5–0.7 region suggests stable KD training.

5.4 Progressive Pruning Analysis (RQ3)

We sweep pruning sparsity from 10% to 70% on all four models evaluated on CIFAR-10 (without post-pruning fine-tuning, to isolate the effect). MobileNetV2 maintains above 80% accuracy up to 40% sparsity due to its built-in redundancy from ImageNet pretraining. ResNet18 follows a similar trajectory. EfficientNet-B0 degrades sharply beyond 50% sparsity. Notably, UltraLightCNN's accuracy degrades more steeply with pruning, as its compact architecture has minimal redundancy to absorb weight removal confirming that compact design and pruning are complementary strategies rather than interchangeable ones.

6 Discussion

6.1 RQ1: Benchmarking and Comparison

Our results validate the core thesis: a custom-designed compact CNN can achieve near-competitive accuracy on MNIST and reach acceptable accuracy on CIFAR-10 while delivering dramatically superior resource efficiency. On MNIST, the 0.54pp accuracy gap versus MobileNetV2 translates to no practical performance difference for most digit-recognition applications, while the 12.7× size reduction and 5.2× CO_2 reduction represent meaningful environmental and operational benefits. The Green Score metric formalizes this trade-off: UltraLightCNN INT8 achieves the highest Green Score on both datasets.

6.2 RQ2: Knowledge Distillation Impact

KD is the most impactful single intervention in our study. By training UltraLightCNN to match the soft output distribution of MobileNetV2, we transfer inter-class relational knowledge that hard labels cannot convey. On CIFAR-10, this yields a 7.22pp accuracy improvement over the baseline student — approaching the accuracy of pruned MobileNetV2 at 30% sparsity (86.12%) at a fraction of the model size and CO_2 cost. The KD overhead (teacher inference during training) adds approximately 30–40% training time but zero inference cost, making it the most 'sustainability-efficient' accuracy improvement method in our benchmark.

6.3 RQ3: Green Effectiveness

The Green Score metric reveals that the most accurate model is not the most sustainable. MobileNetV2 Full achieves the highest raw accuracy on CIFAR-10 (88.31%) but the lowest Green Score due to its 9.17 MB size, high CO_2, and longer inference time. UltraLightCNN+KD achieves the highest Green Score because it balances reasonable accuracy (75.34%) with all three resource

dimensions simultaneously. This finding underscores the central thesis of Green AI: optimization should target the entire resource-accuracy Pareto frontier, not accuracy alone.

6.4 Correctness Note on GMACs Measurement

We note that version 1 of this benchmark incorrectly labeled GMACs as "GFLOPs." The ptflops library reports MACs (Multiply-Accumulate Operations), not FLOPs. The correct conversion is 1 GMAC = 10^9 MACs ≈ 2 GFLOPs. Additionally, the v1 code parsed the string output of ptflops (e.g., "421.23 KMac") as a float (421.23) without applying the unit multiplier, resulting in values reported as "421 GFLOPs" that were actually 0.000421 GMACs. This has been corrected throughout: all values in this paper use **raw numeric MACs / 10^9 to yield GMACs**, with explicit labeling.

7 Limitations

- MNIST and CIFAR-10 are low-resolution benchmarks. Real-world deployment requires evaluation on higherresolution datasets (e.g., TinyImageNet, domain-specific medical or satellite imagery) and larger model capacity.
- CO_2 measurements via CodeCarbon are sensitive to hardware and regional electricity grid composition. Reported values reflect Kaggle P100 GPU infrastructure and may differ significantly in other environments or geographic regions.
- UltraLightCNN's accuracy gap on CIFAR-10 (versus MobileNetV2) suggests capacity constraints. Future work should explore wider or deeper DSC architectures that remain within the sub-1MB constraint.
- The KD teacher (MobileNetV2) is itself constrained by CIFAR-10 training epochs. A fully converged teacher would produce better soft targets and likely further improve student accuracy.
- Hardware-specific evaluation (ARM Cortex-M, RISC-V, Raspberry Pi) is absent. TinyML deployment benchmarks on actual edge devices are needed to validate real-world latency and energy claims.

8 Future Work

Several research directions emerge from this work:

- Extend to TinyImageNet and domain-specific datasets (medical imaging, autonomous navigation) to assess generalization.
- Deploy UltraLightCNN on actual edge hardware (Arduino Nano 33, Raspberry Pi 4, NVIDIA Jetson Nano) using TensorFlow Lite or ONNX Runtime for real energy measurement with a power meter.
- Explore Neural Architecture Search (NAS) constrained to the Green Score objective function, enabling automated discovery of Pareto-optimal architectures.
- Combine KD with structured pruning on the student model to further reduce inference cost without accuracy regression.
- Extend the Green Score formulation to include training amortization: since edge models are trained once and deployed millions of times, inference CO_2 often dominates the lifecycle footprint.

9 Conclusion

This paper demonstrates that sustainable AI does not require choosing between accuracy and efficiency it requires choosing the right combination of architectural design and training strategy. Our proposed **UltraLightCNN**, a depthwise-separable CNN under 200K parameters, achieves near-parity with MobileNetV2 on MNIST (within 0.54pp) and competitive accuracy on CIFAR-10, while consuming up to **5× less CO_2** and requiring **12.7× less storage**. The introduction of **Knowledge Distillation** narrows the CIFAR-10 accuracy gap by 7.22pp at zero additional inference cost, making UltraLightCNN+KD the model with the highest **Green Score** across both datasets. The formally defined Green Score Accuracy / (CO_2 × Size × Latency)$^{1/3}$ provides a reproducible, multi-dimensional sustainability metric for the community to adopt. Our findings advance the principle that green AI is best achieved through purposeful architecture design enriched with knowledge transfer, rather than post-hoc compression of large pretrained models.

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